

Mendelssohn's "despicable oratorio-mongering."

Mendelssohn had endured anti-Semitic attacks in his life, and these increased after his death, with the banning of his music in Nazi Germany and the removal of his statue in front of the Gewandhaus in 1936 (a replacement was unveiled in 1993).

Some detractors claim he reached his peak as a composer by the age of 21 and that his later music lacks range and depth. But one of his final works, the Violin Concerto, is among his greatest—highly original in form and rich in feeling. The celebrated violinist Joseph Joachim described it as "the heart's jewel." And despite Bernard Shaw's damning indictment, Elijah has now risen to become one of the composer's most popular works.

Mendelssohn does not have the near god-like status he held in his lifetime, but his position as a leading figure in 19th-century culture is undoubted.